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ALTHOUGH I'D ONCE BROADCAST a University of Michigan football game in which he played, I knew Gerald Ford only slightly before he succeeded Richard Nixon in the White House. He offered me a choice of virtually any position I wanted in his cabinet, but I wanted to complete my second term as governor and said I'd prefer to remain in Sacramento.

After he became president, a number of Republican leaders around the country began urging me to challenge Ford for the party nomination in 1976. Running for the presidency wasn't something I had planned on. But, as I've said, I had always believed a candidate doesn't make the decision whether to run for president, the people make it, the people let you know whether you should run for office. And so, I agreed to go after the nomination, but pledged to follow the Eleventh Commandment and I did.

Senator Paul Laxalt of Nevada, whom I'd gotten to know and like while we were governors of neighboring states, agreed to serve as general chairman of the campaign. The team of political professionals led by Stu Spencer and Bill Roberts, who had helped oversee my campaigns for governor, had already agreed to work for Ford, so to manage the campaign, my supporters brought in John Sears, a well-respected Washington lawyer who had worked in the White House during the Nixon years.

For the primary campaign, we decided on a simple and straight-forward strategy: Our attacks would be aimed solely at the Democrats and big government, not Gerald Ford.

Our main theme was that I wasn't part of the Washington establishment—I was an outsider—and therefore I offered voters a clear-cut alternative to the Democrats.